Leadership Communication Analysis: The Steve Jobs Case Study

Introduction

Steve Jobs had a way of explaining ideas so that people could follow them easily. In the 2007 iPhone launch, he shows how a product can be presented with confidence. In his 2005 Stanford speech, he shares experiences from his own life. Looking at both examples helps me understand how leaders can communicate with people in different situations.

Golden Circle and Visionary Communication

Applying the Golden Circle to the iPhone launch

Simon Sinek's Golden Circle has three parts: WHY, HOW and WHAT. The main idea is that leaders should first explain why something matters, then show how they will solve a problem, and finally explain what they are offering.

WHY – Why does the product matter? Jobs starts by saying that revolutionary products can change everything (iPhone launch, 00:18). He does not present the iPhone as just another mobile phone. He explains that existing smartphones are difficult to use (03:34–04:38), so people need a simpler option. This helps the audience understand why the product is important.

HOW – How will Apple solve the problem? Jobs explains that Apple has combined music, phone and internet functions in one device. Between 01:27 and 02:49, he introduces the three functions and explains that they are not separate devices. At 06:10–07:12, he demonstrates the touch screen and explains why using fingers can be easier than using a fixed keyboard or stylus.

WHAT – What is Apple offering? At 03:00–03:08, Jobs introduces the iPhone and says Apple is going to reinvent the phone. He then shows the device and explains its features. The audience can see how the idea works instead of only hearing about it.

A product announcement could just give the audience the price, features and release date. Jobs first explains what is wrong with existing phones and then shows how the iPhone is different. I found this approach easier to follow because the audience can understand the reason for the product before seeing all its features.

Influence and Trust in the Stanford Speech

Ethos, Pathos and Logos in Steve Jobs' Speech

In his 2005 Stanford address, Jobs uses ethos, pathos and logos to connect with the graduates.

Ethos – Credibility: Jobs builds trust by talking honestly about difficult moments in his life. At 01:01, he explains that he dropped out of Reed College. At 05:59–06:32, he talks about being fired from Apple and says it was devastating. Sharing these experiences makes his advice feel based on real life, not just theory.

Pathos – Emotion: Jobs shares stories that can make the audience think about their own lives. At 05:38, he starts talking about love and loss. At 09:05, he begins his story about death and explains how his cancer diagnosis affected the way he looked at life. These stories make the speech personal and emotional.

Logos – Reasoning: Jobs also explains his ideas in a logical way. At 05:02–05:22, he says people cannot connect the dots looking forward, but can connect them looking backwards. In simple terms, we may understand the value of an experience only later. His calligraphy classes, which influenced the Macintosh's typography, are an example of this (03:29–04:25).

Frances Frei's Trust Triangle

Frances Frei's Trust Triangle includes authenticity, logic and empathy.

- **Authenticity:** Jobs talks openly about being fired and how painful it was. He does not pretend that everything in his life went well.
- **Logic:** He organises the speech into three stories, which makes it easier to follow. At 00:47, he tells the audience that he is going to share three stories.
- **Empathy:** Jobs understands that graduates are thinking about their future. At 12:28–12:51, he advises them not to spend their lives living according to other people's expectations and encourages them to follow their heart and intuition.

Some graduates may have felt that Jobs' success made his life very different from theirs. However, when he talks about being fired and becoming ill, he also shows that he faced difficult situations. I think this helps the audience connect with him.

Executive Presence and Media Richness

Sylvia Ann Hewlett's executive presence

Sylvia Ann Hewlett explains executive presence through three areas: gravitas, communication and appearance.

Gravitas: Jobs speaks with confidence during the iPhone launch. At 03:08, he says Apple is going to reinvent the phone. This shows that he believes in the product and wants the audience to see its importance.

Communication: Jobs uses simple language and demonstrations. At 02:19, he repeats the three functions, and at 02:49 he explains that they are combined in one device. At 15:26–15:51, he demonstrates the slide-to-unlock feature. Showing the feature makes it easier to understand than explaining it with words alone.

Appearance and body language: The stage is simple, so the audience can focus on the phone. Jobs' casual clothing also fits Apple's informal image. His gestures help direct attention to the product. These details support his presentation, although appearance by itself does not make someone a good leader.

Media Richness Theory: Keynote versus email

Daft and Len gel's Media Richness Theory explains that some communication channels are better than others for sharing complex ideas. A live keynote is a rich medium because the audience can hear Jobs, see his expressions and watch the product demonstration. This helps him explain the iPhone and build excitement.

Email is more suitable for information such as prices, specifications and release dates because people can read it again later. However, email would not create the same excitement or show the product working in real time. For this reason, a keynote is useful for a product launch, while email is better for sharing follow-up details.

Leader Communication Audit Matrix – 2007 iPhone Launch

The scores below range from 1 (weak) to 5 (excellent). The examples are based on the video transcript, and timestamps may vary slightly depending on the version.

Audit area	Score	Evidence from the launch	Module 1 concept
Purpose Clarity	5/5	At 03:00–03:08, Jobs names the iPhone and says Apple is going to reinvent the phone.	Clear purpose and vision
Audience Fit	5/5	At 03:34–04:38, he explains why existing smartphones are difficult to use.	Audience-centred communication
Credibility and Trust	4/5	At 06:10–07:12, he demonstrates the touch screen and explains its benefits. Since it is a product launch, the	Ethos and credibility

		presentation is also promotional.	
Structure and Storytelling	5/5	At 01:27–03:08, he introduces three functions and builds up to the reveal of one device.	Golden Circle and storytelling
Leadership Style	5/5	At 03:08, Jobs presents the iPhone confidently as a new direction for mobile phones.	Visionary leadership
Delivery and Presence	5/5	At 15:26–15:51, he shows how slide-to-unlock works instead of only describing it.	Executive presence and demonstration
Two-Way Engagement	4/5	The demonstrations keep the audience interested, but the launch is mainly a one-way presentation.	Audience engagement and feedback

Conclusion

After looking at both speeches, I feel that good communication is not only about speaking confidently. Leaders also need to think about their audience and explain their ideas clearly. Jobs demonstrates the iPhone instead of only talking about it, and in the Stanford speech he uses experiences from his life to explain his message. These are useful lessons for presentations because examples and personal stories can help people understand an idea.